sapphire, and an emerald—inside the last. There was also coaly grit and a ‘relic’ which ‘had the appearance of a dried twig, though perhaps a trifle heavy . . . the fractured ends or sections, do not, however, show a woody texture.’[15] Various stone pieces including two heavy railing slabs and the remains of a stone umbrella were also found ‘in the vertical axis of the mound’, which probably means they were buried inside the stupa. Why were these buried inside the stupa, and were they part of a previous stupa that had been vandalized? Possibly.

Since the excavations did not yield either a coin or an inscription, it is difficult to precisely date the Bhoria stupa. That it may well have been built in the time of Ashoka, however, can be suggested on the basis of the fact that, like many Mauryan stupas, it is a solid brick structure. An example of a Mauryan brick stupa is the one at Vaishali in Bihar, where the Mauryan enlargement that came to encase the original mud stupa was done in burnt brick. Similarly, the Dharmarajika stupa at Sarnath is made of brick, surmounted by one or more umbrellas set within a square railing.

Was burnt brick used as a construction material in Gujarat in the late centuries BCE? The archaeologist Y.S. Rawat surveyed an early historic fort on the Taranga hill in north Gujarat and suggests it was used fairly early there.[16] The fortified settlement dated to the third century/second century BCE shows burnt-brick construction over granite boulders. Like the bricks of the Bhoria stupa, these were fairly large. The use of brick is, culturally speaking, a significant aberration in Junagadh since this is an area where, from the early medieval period till today, stone is primarily used for construction, good quality stone being locally abundant. The tradition of brick building in Junagadh might have remained an enigma but for the fact that bricks were much used for Buddhist shrines in Ashokan times, and that the emperor had a strong presence in Junagadh.

Ancient literature credits Ashoka with the construction of as many as 84,000 stupas over the relics of the Buddha, which he is supposed to have